

Catch up: America says Hormuz could reopen “today or tomorrow”; Europe responds to border chaos



Photograph: Reuters

Scott Bessent, America’s treasury secretary, said that **Iran** could agree to reopen the **Strait of Hormuz** “today or tomorrow”. The price of Brent crude, the oil benchmark, fell by 6% following his comments to [CNBC](#). Donald Trump has made similar insinuations in recent days. Iran has denied negotiating with America, but is in discussions with Oman over the waterway.

The **European Union’s** interior ministers held emergency talks on Tuesday about border security. The European Commission president, Ursula von der Leyen, said the [Ceuta crisis](#) showed the need to “further strengthen [EU] borders”. Meanwhile, British and French coastal patrols rescued at least 170 migrants attempting to cross the English Channel in a boat that caught fire.

Ukraine hit multiple warehouses across **Russia** overnight, including two run by Wildberries, killing five people. Its army has previously said that the [online retailer’s facilities](#) had been used as military factories. On Monday a [Ukrainian](#) drone crashed into a busy beach in Russia, killing seven people and injuring 40 more, according to local authorities.

Moderna began the first human trial of a vaccine against the Bundibugyo strain of **Ebola**. The strain has killed some 1,650 people, mostly in the Democratic Republic of Congo, in the second-largest [outbreak of Ebola](#) on record. Moderna's experimental mRNA-1469 vaccine, which is based on the same technology as its covid-19 jab, will be administered to 80 adults.

McDonald's attracted fewer diners than expected in the second quarter, despite introducing a range of budget options for poorer customers. The American fast-food chain said that sales in its home market grew by 0.8%, down from 2.5% over the same period a year ago. The company's executives said not enough customers knew about its cheaper menus, and that the World Cup failed to drive sales as expected.

Finland's safety regulator approved the world's first permanent **repository for nuclear waste**, which plans to open on the country's west coast. Spent fuel from the Olkiluoto and Loviisa nuclear power plants will be sealed in canisters and deposited in tunnels some 430 metres underground. The government will review the repository's application for an operating permit in the autumn.

Vietnam will build its first memorial to **North Korean** servicemen who died fighting on its side during the **Vietnam War** in the 1960s. Vietnam has previously done little to acknowledge the dozens of North Korean pilots who helped it to defeat America. The memorial will be built during renovations of a cemetery in the northern Bac Ninh province, where 14 pilots were buried before their remains were repatriated.

Figure of the day: 12,000 tonnes. Zimbabwe's expected export of blueberries this year, 40 times more than in 2017. [Read about Africa's latest boom.](#)

US in Brief: Trump's new tariffs head to court



Photograph: Getty Images

A group of 25 Democrat-led states sued the Trump administration over its latest round of **tariffs**. Levies of between 10% and 12.5% were **imposed on 60 countries** that the government said had failed to police the imports of goods made with forced labour. They came into effect last month. The Supreme Court struck down Donald Trump's first round of tariffs in February, but the White House insists the new charges are lawful.

Meanwhile, 24 states and the District of Columbia sued the administration over its attempts to access the **personal data** of people on a **benefits programme**. The government says accessing the information will help prevent fraud in the "Temporary Assistance for Needy Families" scheme. But the states, which include California and New York, argue that the data-sharing plan is an unlawful attempt to support the administration's **campaign to deport** illegal migrants.

The **Senate** advanced a bill to fund the federal government until December in a 89-4 vote. Senators from both parties are keen to avoid a **government shutdown** in the run-up to the midterm elections in November; they hope the agreement can pass the chamber before they go on recess at the end of the week. To avoid a shutdown, the bill would also need to pass in the House of

Representatives before the government's current stopgap funding expires at the end of September.

Mr Trump lashed out at **Jeanine Pirro**, the us attorney for the District of Columbia, after the Justice Department said that recent damage to the **Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool** was caused by the administration's renovation of the site in Washington, rather than vandalism. The president said Ms Pirro "choked" by dropping vandalism charges against David Hearn, a former Olympian, last week. Mr Trump was reportedly considering firing her, though she remained in post after visiting the White House on Monday.

The Senate Judiciary Committee will vote today on whether to advance **Todd Blanche's** nomination for attorney-general. Two Republican holdouts, Thom Tillis and John Cornyn, said they would back Mr Blanche, meaning he will probably progress to a full Senate confirmation this week. Mr Blanche won their support after formally rescinding parts of a deal the Justice Department [had struck with Mr Trump in May](#). Democrats said Mr Blanche's assurances were vague.

Can SpaceX keep it up?



Photograph: Reuters

On Tuesday SpaceX, Elon Musk's rocket and AI firm, will publish its first set of results since going public on June 12th in [the biggest IPO ever](#). Since then the firm's engineering has been going well. The most recent test flight of Starship, a reusable mega-rocket, was a success: the second stage splashed down gently in the Indian Ocean on July 24th. That will provide valuable data about the performance of its heat shield, one of the biggest factors in achieving rapid reusability. Both Starlink, the satellite-internet service that is SpaceX's only profitable unit, and its ambitions for extraterrestrial data centres depend on Starship's technology.

After an initial frenzy, though, investors have cooled on the firm of late. SpaceX has announced deals with Google, Anthropic and others to lease them capacity in its existing data centres, plus a contract with America's Space Force worth \$1.6bn. But its shares are no longer sky-high: they currently trade at around \$114, well below the \$135 IPO price.

Israel and Lebanon talk, again



Photograph: Getty Images

On Tuesday envoys from Israel and Lebanon will meet in Rome for their seventh round of talks this year. In June they agreed to a ceasefire and to a deal that commits the Lebanese army to disarm [Hizbullah](#), an Iran-backed Shia militia. In return, Israel would withdraw from land it occupies in south Lebanon. Last month Israel and Lebanon started applying the agreement in two “pilot zones”. But it may be some time before the agreement is fully implemented. Hizbullah refuses to hand over its weapons, and the Lebanese army is reluctant to confront it.

Israel continues to carry out air strikes on the militia, despite the supposed ceasefire. Hundreds of thousands of Lebanese are still displaced. Those who have returned to the south often find their homes too badly damaged to stay. Israel’s defence minister bragged on Sunday that the army had razed two dozen villages. There is little hope of rebuilding until the war comes to a lasting end.

Democrats fight for Michigan



Photograph: AP

A bruising primary campaign ends on Tuesday, when Democrats in Michigan choose their Senate candidate. The election pits Abdul El-Sayed, a progressive backed by Bernie Sanders and Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, against Haley Stevens, a moderate preferred by more mainstream politicians. Dr El-Sayed, a charismatic public-health specialist, supports universal health care and eliminating military aid to Israel. Ms Stevens is an unflashy party loyalist with a successful record in Congress.

The race [is emblematic](#) of the bitter struggle between insurgent and establishment figures within the party. But the stakes are particularly high in Michigan, a state vital to Democrats' hopes of winning a Senate majority. The victor will then face Mike Rogers, a former congressman who has converted to Trumpism. Polls are tight, but favour Dr El-Sayed. If the race comes down to who is more populist—a label both Democratic candidates embrace—he has the edge there, too.

Merger mania gives record payouts to Wall Street



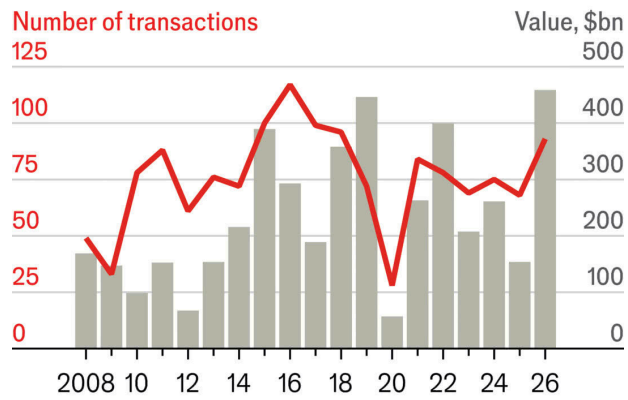
Photograph: Alamy

Mega-deals are back. So are mega-fees. The biggest prize is going to Goldman Sachs, which will make \$110m for advising Electronic Arts, a video-game maker, on its \$55bn deal to take itself private. The transaction, the largest-ever leveraged buyout, closes on Tuesday. The buyers are a consortium consisting of Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund, Affinity Partners—Jared Kushner's investment firm—and Silver Lake, a private-equity investor.

American **m&a is booming**. The total value of announced deals to acquire publicly traded American firms during the first half of 2026 was the highest in nearly 20 years, according to Deal Point Data, a research firm. Yet, by number of transactions, that period ranked just fifth among six-month stretches. Big deals mean big paydays. Only 16 acquisitions of American public companies have paid out fees of \$100m or more to any single bank. Half of those have occurred since 2025.

Big bets

US, announced public-target M&A transactions*
January-June data



*Excluding withdrawn deals

Source: Deal Point Data

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: The Althing in Iceland is the oldest form of what type of institution?

Monday: What happens on the Orient Express in the title of the Agatha Christie novel?

*Don't be fooled by your own
wisdom.*

Witold Gombrowicz